

L2-5 Grey Zones Between Institutional Abstraction and Operational Reality

Chapter 3 System Drift: How Grey Zones Rewrite System Behavior

Yaowei Huang



Chapter 3 System Drift: How Grey Zones Rewrite System Behavior

In the preceding chapters, the formation of the system, the stress acting on its boundaries, the introduction of redundancy, and the exit of judgment together constitute the fundamental preconditions of system operation at different levels. Space is organized through risk, workflow, and system boundaries; boundaries shift under high-energy disturbance; redundancy and buffering mechanisms are introduced to maintain operational continuity; and certain conditions remain unresolved within their original judgment windows, subsequently carried forward as unclosed states.

Within this structure, grey zones do not emerge as accidental deviations, but as outcomes produced through the interaction of these preconditions. When uncompleted judgments are continuously carried within institutional boundaries and repeatedly invoked through various structural mechanisms, their status no longer remains at the level of unclosed conditions. Instead, they begin to acquire stable positions within system operation. At this stage, the question is no longer whether these conditions are resolved, but how they continue to participate in system operation without being reintroduced into judgment.

In this process, the system does not cease to function due to deviation. Its boundaries and rules remain formally unchanged. However, the operational pathways originally established through judgment are gradually replaced by pathways based on structural carrying, buffering, and repeated invocation. Unresolved conditions do not disappear; rather, through continuous reuse, they detach from their original judgment positions and begin to participate in shaping the system's actual operational logic.

Therefore, this chapter does not examine how grey zones are retained, but how, when unclosed conditions continue to participate in operation without re-entering judgment, the system maintains surface stability while its operational logic gradually diverges from the paths originally defined by design and judgment.



Chapter 3 System Drift: How Grey Zones Rewrite System Behavior

1. Repeated Invocation and State Transformation of Unclosed Conditions

When certain conditions are not completed within their original judgment pathways, they are not removed from the system, but continue to be carried forward as unclosed states in subsequent operations. The exit of judgment within its corresponding time window does not eliminate the condition itself; rather, it interrupts the linkage between the condition and its original judgment pathway. As a result, these conditions no longer exist as objects requiring redefinition, but enter a state in which they are implicitly accepted within ongoing operation.

Under continuous system operation, such unclosed conditions do not remain isolated events. As similar situations recur across different nodes, these conditions begin to be invoked again in similar forms. They no longer rely on the reactivation of their original judgment pathways, but enter operational processes directly through existing structural arrangements. Conditions that originally required definition gradually lose their characteristics as “unfinished objects,” and instead present themselves as recognizable and predictable patterns.

The formation of these patterns does not depend on formal redefinition by the institution, nor on their explicit incorporation into the rule system. Institutional boundaries remain abstractly unchanged, and rules continue to exist in their original form. However, in actual operation, these unclosed conditions begin to be handled in stable and consistent ways. Their entry into the system is no longer triggered through judgment, but completed directly through existing structures. This shift does not alter the unresolved nature of the condition itself, but it changes its position within the system.

As a result, unclosed conditions no longer exist merely as states being carried. Through repeated invocation, they gradually transform into reusable operational conditions. They no longer wait to be re-evaluated, but are reintroduced into the system through established pathways. The original entry mechanism based on judgment is gradually replaced by a pathway grounded in repetition and familiarity, allowing these conditions to continuously participate in system operation without being redefined.

At this stage, the system has not yet exhibited structural drift. Its operation remains within existing boundaries. However, the emergence of unclosed conditions as reusable states already establishes the precondition for subsequent structural transformation: the entry of conditions into the system is no longer determined solely by judgment, but is increasingly guided by existing operational patterns.



Chapter 3 System Drift: How Grey Zones Rewrite System Behavior

2. Structural Reversal of Carrying Mechanisms and the Formation of Operational Dependency

As unclosed conditions are repeatedly invoked as reusable states, the pathways through which they enter system operation gradually stabilize. In this process, the structural mechanisms originally responsible for carrying these conditions begin to shift in function. These mechanisms were not designed to resolve conditions, but to allow unclosed states to be carried forward without re-entering judgment, through spatial containment, temporal deferral, capacity buffering, or relational adjustment. Their role was to sustain continuity, rather than to alter the condition itself.

However, as these unclosed conditions are repeatedly invoked in stable forms, the role of these carrying mechanisms is no longer limited to passive accommodation. The system's dependence on them increases progressively, transforming them from auxiliary structures that enable continuity into conditions that make operation possible. What was originally introduced as a response to uncertainty gradually assumes responsibility for maintaining the overall operational logic.

This transformation does not occur through formal redefinition. The mechanisms themselves retain their original structural form and are not explicitly reassigned new roles within the institutional framework. Yet in practice, their function has shifted. They no longer simply absorb uncertainty arising from unresolved conditions, but begin to take on functions that were originally associated with judgment pathways. Instead of reactivating judgment to re-establish definition, the system sustains operation by relying on these mechanisms within the existing structure.

The formation of this dependency is not marked by explicit structural substitution, but emerges gradually through repeated invocation. The use of these mechanisms transitions from occasional response to routine pathway, allowing them to become stable components of system operation without being explicitly identified as such. As this process continues, their position within the system changes: they are no longer confined to peripheral buffering layers, but move closer to the operational core.

As a result, these mechanisms, originally intended to carry unclosed conditions, are progressively transformed into foundational conditions for system operation. System continuity is no longer sustained solely by original judgment pathways, but is partially supported by these mechanisms. Unclosed conditions persist not because they are resolved, but because a structural arrangement exists that allows them to continue without resolution.



Chapter 3 System Drift: How Grey Zones Rewrite System Behavior

3 Replacement of Operational Pathways and System Drift

Once unclosed conditions have become reusable states and the system has formed dependency on the corresponding carrying mechanisms, the operational pathways originally established through judgment begin to change. The entry of conditions into the system is no longer determined exclusively through judgment, but is increasingly mediated by existing structures and established operational patterns. Judgment pathways are not explicitly removed; they remain present in form, but their functional role in actual operation is progressively diminished. In this process, the system does not exhibit immediate instability or disruption. Its boundaries remain formally defined, and its rule structure continues to exist without explicit modification. Operational continuity is preserved. However, the manner in which conditions enter and are organized within the system has shifted. Instead of being derived primarily through judgment, they are increasingly introduced through pathways shaped by repetition, structural carrying, and established dependency.

As this shift continues, two parallel pathways emerge within the system. On one hand, the original judgment-based pathways remain embedded within the institutional structure, preserving formal definitions and boundary conditions. On the other hand, a set of operational pathways, formed through repeated invocation and structural reliance, becomes increasingly dominant in actual practice. These two pathways do not directly conflict, but their domains gradually diverge: judgment pathways persist at the level of formal structure, while operational pathways take over the organization of real processes.

When this divergence stabilizes over time, the system's operational logic begins to drift. The system no longer operates strictly according to the pathways defined by its original design and judgment framework, but instead maintains continuity through an alternative set of pathways that have emerged within its own operation. Rules remain in place and continue to define the system's boundaries, but their role in determining actual operation is no longer singular.

As a result, the system does not depart from its formal definition, nor does it exhibit explicit rule violation. However, through the transformation of entry conditions and the gradual substitution of operational pathways, its internal logic is continuously restructured. This shift does not occur as a discrete event, but as a gradual process in which the system, while maintaining surface consistency, undergoes a sustained and largely unobservable transformation in its mode of operation.



L2-5 Grey Zones Between Institutional Abstraction and Operational Reality

Across the first three chapters, grey zones are not treated as isolated phenomena, but emerge through a continuous structural progression across different layers of the system. Their formation does not result from the absence of rules, but from the interpretive space inherent in institutional abstraction when confronted with specific conditions. Their persistence is not due to a lack of recognition, but to the non-completion of judgment within its designated pathway, allowing these conditions to remain within institutional boundaries. Their subsequent evolution does not take the form of explicit structural adjustment, but unfolds through repeated invocation and structural carrying, gradually entering system operation.

Throughout this progression, the system does not cease to function. Space continues to be organized according to existing boundaries; boundaries remain under stress in the presence of disturbance; redundancy and buffering mechanisms sustain operational continuity; and certain conditions continue to be carried forward without re-entering judgment. In this context, grey zones move beyond interpretive ambiguity or localized states, and, through repeated invocation, acquire stable positions within the system, gradually participating in the formation of its operational structure.

As unclosed conditions become reusable states and the system forms dependency on carrying mechanisms, the pathways originally established through judgment begin to shift. System operation is no longer derived solely from rules and judgment, but is sustained through existing structures and operational pathways, without altering its formal boundaries. Rules remain in place and continue to define the system's scope, but their role in organizing actual operation is no longer exclusive.

Thus, the formation, retention, and repeated invocation of grey zones do not constitute a set of discrete events, but form a continuous structural chain: judgment is not completed, conditions are retained; retained conditions are repeatedly invoked, and their states stabilize; structural mechanisms are repeatedly relied upon, and operational pathways shift. Within this chain, the system does not depart from its formal definition, yet at the level of operation, it gradually develops a mode of organization distinct from its original design logic.

At the institutional level, what is described in this chapter is not system failure nor rule deviation, but a mode of operation: under conditions where judgment pathways are no longer continuously activated, the system sustains continuity through structural carrying and repeated invocation, and, without altering its formal boundaries, gradually replaces its original judgment-based pathways with operational pathways, resulting in a system that remains stable in form while its internal logic has undergone structural transformation.

Yaowei Huang
20260412

